

Xiaomi 17 Ultra

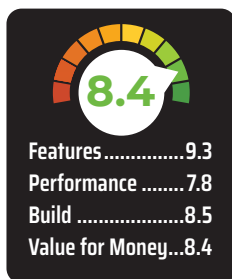
This is what ultra should mean

In the smartphone space, the word 'ultra' has remained untouched by the 'Pro fatigue' that most brands have allowed to hollow out their own naming conventions. While 'Pro' has become a suffix thrown around loosely to justify incremental upgrades, 'Ultra' still implies ambition that goes above and beyond. The largest sensors, the most capable optics, the most powerful processor, a premiumness that defies the initial in-hand feel and a price to match. Up until last year, the cadence has been slow too. This year though, things are looking very different since we have a barrage of Ultra-phones that have arrived in quick succession, giving Indian buyers a taste of what's possible if cost is not an issue. Samsung has occupied this space with relative comfort for years with their Galaxy S-series flagships but this year it has competition in the form of the Xiaomi 17 Ultra. The Xiaomi 17 Ultra is Rs 1,39,999 of camera ambition backed by a 1-inch type Leica-tuned main sensor, a 200 MP continuous optical zoom telephoto and the Snapdragon 8 Elite Gen 5. On paper, it is the most complete ultra-tier package currently available in India.

DESIGN AND BUILD

At 8.29 mm and 218.4 g, the Xiaomi 17 Ultra is lighter than most competing ultra-tier phones. A 1-inch sensor and a periscope telephoto assembly with a moving lens demand physical space and weight. But the reason for that comparative lightness is the back panel is made from aerospace-grade fiberglass rather than glass. It is smooth, slightly

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cool to the touch and passes for glass convincingly in casual use. The aluminium frame is solid, the circular volume buttons have a satisfying tactile click and the micro-curved edges make extended one-handed use comfortable.

The camera module's placement despite the sensor bulk behind the glass, does not jut aggressively from the back panel. It sits centrally, slides into a pocket cleanly, and your index finger finds its lower edge naturally when shooting handheld for extended periods.

In terms of durability, during my extended daily use, the camera module glass, protected by Corning Glass 7i, remains scratch-free after being carried in bags and pockets alongside keys and other objects. The display, covered by Xiaomi Shield Glass 3.0, resisted micro-scratches with equal stubborn-

ness and the IP68 water resistance covers submersion in up to 6 m of fresh water for 30 minutes. The ultrasonic fingerprint reader is well-placed and consistently accurate.

DISPLAY

The 6.9-inch HyperRGB OLED panel is, without much argument, one of the finest displays on any smartphone in the market today. The term 'HyperRGB' refers to a full RGB subpixel matrix: every pixel has its own red, green and blue subpixels, unlike the PenTile arrangement which use a shared subpixel arrangement across neighboring pixels.

This enables sharper text, more accurate colour and a more natural image at any brightness level, even with a pixel density of 416 ppi across 2608 x 1200 pixels.

The LTPO implementation is particularly well-tuned and precise. The refresh rate scales intelligently from 1 Hz when the screen is idle all the way to 120 Hz during active use, and the system makes sensible decisions throughout: Chrome, system menus, and even the YouTube browsing interface operate at 120 Hz, with the display stepping down to match a video's frame rate only when playback actually begins.

At 12-bit colour depth with HDR10+, Dolby Vision and HDR Vivid support, the display handles HDR content with the depth you would expect from a premium OLED panel. The peak brightness at 3500 nits holds up in direct sunlight without compromise and the 2160 Hz PWM dimming is a welcome addition for anyone sensitive to screen flicker, keeping the display comfortable at lower brightness settings over long sessions.

THE CAMERAS

The camera system is the central argument for why this phone exists. The rear triple camera system spans focal lengths from 14mm to 100mm under Leica's VARIO-APO-SUMMILUX